Indian PM Vishwanath Pratap Singh, and other top but uninterested politicians such as Rajiv Gandhi. No response was forthcoming. Instead, Sarwari found himself in a 'C' grade cell (meant for petty criminals and smugglers) in Delhi's Tihar Jail under the Foreigner's Registration Act on 11 June 1990. His six-month Indian visa, which he had lost with his passport, had expired and his presence on Indian soil was deemed illegal. As there were no provisions to extradite him, a request for the same from Kabul was summarily rejected by New Delhi.

He languished in jail and was dragged unceremoniously, with his hands and feet tightly chained, more than thirty-nine times, for hearings at the Tis Hazari Court in Delhi. According to reports, Sarwari was not even allowed to meet officials from the United Nations while in prison.[12] Though he was provided a legal counsel who fought his case relentlessly, not much came out of it. After thirteen months in jail, a fine of Rs. 5,000 (approx. 77 USD), tremendous humiliation, and active intervention by Amnesty International, Sarwari was secretly put on a plane in July 1991 and deported to where he had come from—Yemen.[13] A disappointed Sarwari made his frustration with India amply clear. Calling his detention 'illegal' and out of 'political vendetta', Sarwari castigated New Delhi's behavior as a 'shame for Indian democracy', something he had not expected from a 'friendly country' like India.[14]

Arguably, this is an obscure and strategically inconsequential case. Sarwari was little known internationally, hardly remembered historically, stood against Najibullah who was India's strategic ally, was responsible for murder and torture, and gravitated towards Pakistan for political support. But, as this book shows, at the heart of this ostensibly unimportant case lays the contradiction of India's policy approach towards Afghanistan. The idea of political neutrality, if one ever existed, despite India's passionate advocacy of the same, stood belied. This was the first time India facilitated a politically motivated arrest of a senior Afghan politician to ensure the political survival of an equally violent ally: an ally, one should say, of whom India was growing wary even before his actual ouster from power in 1992. Clamour for a more accommodative approach towards Najibullah's opponents had been growing steadily in New Delhi since the mid-1980s. The choice that Indian policymakers faced, thus, was real. They could have let Sarwari go and adjusted their Afghanistan policy if the coup had succeeded.